

ESSENTIAL

Study Permit Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - DLI, dual intent, work rights, PGWP, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Study Permit is - and isn't

A Study Permit lets you enrol in a program longer than 6 months at a Designated Learning Institution (DLI) - a school, college, or university IRCC has approved to host international students. It's decided under IRPA/IRPR by an IRCC visa officer. A permit alone doesn't grant entry to Canada (a separate TRV or eTA may also be needed to travel, depending on your nationality), and it doesn't automatically authorize any particular kind of work - your specific work rights are governed by the conditions printed on your permit.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Get accepted	Receive a Letter of Acceptance from a DLI, and a Provincial/Territorial Attestation Letter (PAL) if your situation requires one.
2. Apply online	Complete the application through your IRCC secure account using your Letter of Acceptance details.
3. Pay fees	Pay the processing fee, plus a separate biometric fee unless exempt.
4. Give biometrics	Attend a Visa Application Centre (VAC) for fingerprints and a photo, unless exempt.
5. Submit documents	Upload financial evidence and your study plan - see the Document Checklist.
6. Decision	Most applications are decided on the written file. Processing times vary significantly by country and time of year - check current times on IRCC's website.
7. Get your permit	If approved, you'll typically receive a Port of Entry (POE) Letter of Introduction - the actual Study Permit is issued by a border services officer when you arrive in Canada, not before.

“Dual intent” applies here too

YOU CAN HAVE DUAL INTENT

As with the Visitor Visa, Canadian law explicitly recognises “dual intent” (IRPA section 22(2)) for Study Permit applicants: you can intend to apply for permanent residence after your studies while still qualifying for a temporary Study Permit now. What the officer needs to be satisfied of is that you would leave Canada by the end of your authorized stay if you don't obtain further status - not that you have no long-term interest in Canada at all.

Work rights while studying

Study Permit holders enrolled full-time in an eligible program at a DLI can generally work off-campus during their studies, subject to a weekly hour cap during regular academic sessions and no cap during scheduled breaks (reading week, summer, winter holidays) - the exact weekly limit has been changed by IRCC more than once in recent years, so check the current limit on your specific permit and on IRCC's website rather than assuming a fixed number. On-campus work is generally not subject to the same off-campus cap. Self-employment and some other categories are treated differently - your own permit's conditions govern what you're actually allowed to do.

After your studies: Post-Graduation Work Permit (PGWP)

Many graduates from an eligible program at an eligible DLI can apply for a Post-Graduation Work Permit, a separate open work permit that doesn't require a job offer. Eligibility rules for the PGWP (field-of-study alignment, language requirements, and which programs qualify) have changed significantly and more than once in recent policy updates - confirm your specific program's current PGWP eligibility with your DLI and on IRCC's website before relying on it as part of your plans.

Frequently asked questions

Do I need a separate TRV or eTA to travel?

A Study Permit approval and travel authorization are related but distinct - depending on your nationality, you may also need a TRV or an eTA to actually board your flight or enter Canada. Check what your approval letter and IRCC's website say applies to you.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for how reapplication and judicial review work.